STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



KPIS

DASHBOARDS THAT GET USED

Few's one screen at a glance, how sure people feel with data, the bullet graph, who uses dashboards and for what, five design mistakes, and a card for a dashboard that gets used.

21% of 9,000 employees in nine countries said they were confident in their data literacy skills.

ACCENTURE & QLIK, 2020

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NO. 37 · KPIS

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Many companies have more dashboards than decisions. What is a dashboard for, who can read it, who actually uses it, and how do you tell a screen that gets used from one that is merely switched on?

Stephen Few's definition is narrow: the most important information on one screen, monitored at a glance. In a 2019 survey of 9,000 employees in nine countries, 21% were confident in their data literacy and 74% felt overwhelmed or unhappy working with data. In Finland only about a quarter of the sales managers who answered a 2010 survey used a dashboard. Few's bullet graph replaces the gauge with one line, and a review of health care studies links dashboards that are easy to reach with better care.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

One screen, one glance

In 2004 Stephen Few defined a dashboard narrowly: a visual display of the most important information needed to reach one or more objectives, arranged on a single screen so it can be monitored at a glance.

01
The most important
what the objectives need, not everything that can be measured

02
One screen
no scrolling, no switching: short-term memory holds little

03
At a glance
summaries and exceptions, read in an instant

Later Few sharpened it: a mainly visual display that people use to monitor current conditions rapidly, conditions that need a timely response in a specific role. By that test, he wrote in 2017, only 2 of the 28 examples in The Big Book of Dashboards were rapid-monitoring displays; the others may be useful, but they serve other purposes.

OUR READING

A screen full of charts is not yet a dashboard. Ask who looks at it, how often, and what they do next.

Sources: Stephen Few, Perceptual Edge, 2017; Stephen Few, O'Reilly Media (2nd ed. 2013, Analytics Press), 2006 (via UXmatters, 2007; Few's white paper, 2006)

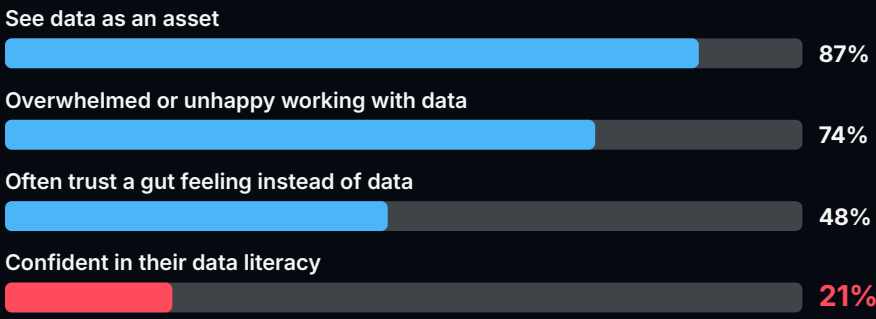
The definitions are Few's; the 2004 wording was checked where he quotes it himself in 2017. The count of 2 in 28 is his judgement of another book; nothing was measured.

THE NUMBERS

Data that overwhelm

In September 2019 Opinium surveyed 9,000 full-time employees in nine countries, Germany among them, for Accenture and Qlik. Most saw data as an asset; few felt sure using it.

EMPLOYEES IN NINE COUNTRIES, SEPTEMBER 2019 (SELF-REPORTED)



In a 2022 Forrester Consulting survey for Tableau of more than 2,000 people in ten countries, 82% of decision-makers expected basic data literacy in every department, but only 39% of organisations offered data training to all employees.

OUR READING

People read dashboards, and a clear screen does nothing for someone who avoids numbers.

Sources: Accenture & Qlik for The Data Literacy Project, survey by Opinium, 2020; Forrester Consulting, commissioned by Tableau, 2022 (via Help Net Security, 2022)

Both studies were commissioned by firms that sell analytics software, and both rest on self-reports. For Albania we have no comparable figure.

THE MODEL

A line instead of a gauge

Few designed the bullet graph to replace the meters and gauges common on dashboards. In a small space it shows one measure, compares it with a target and places it in ranges such as poor, satisfactory and good.

01	02	03	04	05
Label	**Scale**	**Measure**	**Comparison**	**Ranges**
names the measure	one linear axis, usually from zero	a dark bar, the most visible part	a short cross line: target or last year	two to five shades, ideally three

Few advises shades of one colour, dark for poor and light for good, rather than separate hues that people with colour blindness may not tell apart. A linear design, he writes, also takes less space and is read more efficiently than a round gauge.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE, ONE LINE ON A SHIFT DASHBOARD

Measure	on-time departures this week: 91%
Target	a cross line at 95%
Ranges	below 85% poor, 85–95% satisfactory, above 95% good

One line: below target, in the middle range. The figures are made up.

Source: Stephen Few, Perceptual Edge, 2013

The parts and defaults follow Few's design specification (2006, revised 2013). The colour advice is his recommendation and has not been tested as a standard.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Who uses them, and for what

At the end of 2010 Oana Velcu-Laitinen and Ogan Yigitbasioglu surveyed senior sales managers at 851 Finnish companies about dashboards. 145 answered, and only about a quarter of them used one.

SALES MANAGERS WHO ANSWERED, FINLAND, END OF 2010 (NUMBER, OF 145)



Seven of the 36 had built theirs in Excel. Users ranked communication and consistency first of four purposes, ahead of monitoring, and data quality went with use. A 2015 review of 11 health care studies found that where clinicians could reach dashboards easily, as a screen saver for example, use went with better care processes and patient outcomes.

OUR READING

A dashboard people have to go looking for is rarely looked at. Put it where the work happens.

Sources: Oana Velcu-Laitinen & Ogan M. Yigitbasioglu, International Journal of Digital Accounting Research, 2012; Dawn Dowding et al., International Journal of Medical Informatics, 2015

A small sample (17% responded) and correlations that do not prove cause; 47 is the rest of the 109 non-users. The health care review finds only some evidence.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Is anyone looking?

A dashboard can be checked twice: against Few's list of common design mistakes, and against what people do with it. The first takes an hour; the second takes a month of meetings.

Five of Few's thirteen common mistakes

1. exceeding the boundaries of one screen
2. too little context: no target, no comparison
3. excessive detail or precision
4. a deficient measure
5. misusing or overusing colour

1 **Name the user and the decision**
If no one can say which decision a number serves, it belongs in a report.

2 **Count actions, not views**
In each review, note which number led to a step, an owner and a date.

3 **Remove what no one used**
A measure that triggered nothing for a quarter leaves the screen.

Source: Stephen Few, O'Reilly Media (2nd ed. 2013, Analytics Press), 2006 (via UXmatters, 2007; Few's white paper, 2006)

The mistakes are from Few (2006); the steps are the editors' proposal and have not been tested.

More in the essay KPIs do not improve in Excel

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The dashboard card

Fill it in before you build the screen, and again after a month. If a line stays empty, the dashboard is not ready.

01 Who looks at it the role, and how often: every shift, day or week

02 The decision it serves one sentence: what changes when the number moves

03 Three to five measures each with its definition and its source

04 The comparison target, last week or last year, for every measure

05 When it is read the meeting or the moment, and who leads it

06 What triggers action the threshold, who acts, by when

07 What we removed measures that led to no action in a month

Sources: Stephen Few, Perceptual Edge, 2017; Stephen Few, O'Reilly Media (2nd ed. 2013, Analytics Press), 2006 (via UXmatters, 2007; Few's white paper, 2006)

Drawn up by the editors, after Few's definition of a dashboard (2004, 2017) and his book (2006).

Open the tool: Shift Pulse stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-pulse/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Information Dashboard Design: The Effective Visual Communication of Data
Stephen Few, O'Reilly Media (2nd ed. 2013, Analytics Press), 2006 · via UXmatters, 2007; Few's white paper, 2006

There's Nothing Mere About Semantics
Stephen Few, Perceptual Edge, 2017
https://www.perceptualedge.com/blog/?p=2793

The Human Impact of Data Literacy
Accenture & Qlik for The Data Literacy Project, survey by Opinium, 2020
https://www.qlik.com/us/news/company/press-room/press-releases/data-skills-gap-is-costing-organizations-billions-in-lost-productivity

Building Data Literacy: The Key to Better Decisions, Greater Productivity, and Data-Driven Organizations
Forrester Consulting, commissioned by Tableau, 2022 · via Help Net Security, 2022

Bullet Graph Design Specification
Stephen Few, Perceptual Edge, 2013
https://www.perceptualedge.com/articles/misc/Bullet_Graph_Design_Spec.pdf

The Use of Dashboards in Performance Management: Evidence from Sales Managers
Oana Velcu-Laitinen & Ogan M. Yigitbasioglu, International Journal of Digital Accounting Research, 2012
https://doi.org/10.4192/1577-8517-v12_2

Dashboards for improving patient care: Review of the literature
Dawn Dowding et al., International Journal of Medical Informatics, 2015
https://eprints.whiterose.ac.uk/84905/

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html